

Word family: **world / worlds / worldly / worldwide / worldview**

Base word: world

Plural: worlds

Related forms: worldly, worldwide, worldview

Useful extensions: outside world, real world, world-famous, world-class, worldwide, worldview

Part of speech: mainly noun (名詞) / adjective-related compounds (相關複合詞)

Your sentence:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside **world**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **world** does **not** specifically mean planet Earth.

Outside world means the **external environment and everyday reality surrounding a person** — other people, traffic, conversations, workplaces, activities, noises, and so on.

繁體中文: **自己私人空間或內在體驗以外的整個外部現實環境，包括周圍的人、活動、聲音和日常生活**

中文翻譯:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside world.”

「那感覺就像有人替整個**外界／周圍的現實世界**按下了靜音鍵一樣。」

the outside world = 自己或封閉空間以外的外界現實、人群及活動

1. **the world = Earth and everything on it (地球及其上的一切) — 世界; 地球**

Meaning: Planet Earth considered as the place where humans, animals, countries, and societies exist.

Practice 1

> “People around the **world** watched the event.”

「**世界各地**的人都觀看了這項活動。」

Practice 2

> “The **world** is facing serious environmental challenges.”

「**全球／整個世界**正面對嚴重的環境挑戰。」

the world = 地球以及生活在地球上的人類、國家和自然環境的整體

2. **the world = all people / human society (全人類／人類社會) — 世人; 全世界的人**

Meaning: People everywhere, or human society considered collectively.

Practice 3

> “The whole **world** seemed to know about the story.”

「似乎**全世界的人**都知道這件事。」

Practice 4

> “She wanted to show the **world** what she could do.”

「她想向**世人／全世界的人**證明自己的能力。」

the world = 全體人類或整個人類社會

This is related to #1, but the focus is on **people**, not the planet itself.

3. **world = external environment/reality (自身以外的外部現實) — 外界; 外部世界**

This is the sense closest to your original sentence.

Practice 5 — Original

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside **world**.”

「那感覺就像有人替整個**外界**按下了靜音鍵一樣。」

Practice 6

> “She closed the door and shut out the **world** for an hour.”

「她關上門，讓自己有一個小時**與外界隔絕**。」

Practice 7

> “The headphones helped him disconnect from the **world** around him.”

「耳機令他暫時與**周圍的外界環境**抽離。」

world = 某人自身以外、由其他人、活動和環境構成的外部現實

4. **world** = particular area of activity or profession (某個活動／專業領域) —界; 領域; 圈子

Meaning: A particular sphere of work, interest, culture, or activity.

Practice 8

> “She is well known in the fashion **world**.”

「她在**時裝界**很有名。」

Practice 9

> “Technology is changing the business **world** rapidly.”

「科技正在迅速改變**商業界／商業領域**。」

world = 由某個共同職業、興趣或活動形成的領域或圈子

Common examples:

* **business world** = 商界

* **art world** = 藝術界

* **fashion world** = 時裝界

* **academic world** = 學術界

* **sports world** = 體育界

These are all one underlying sense.

5. **world** = particular social environment/community (某種生活圈／社會環境) — 圈子; 生活環境

Meaning: A particular social setting or community in which someone lives or operates.

Practice 10

> “He grew up in a very different **world** from mine.”

「他的成長**生活環境／社會圈子**跟我的非常不同。」

Practice 11

> “She entered a **world** of wealthy clients and luxury hotels.”

「她進入了一個由富裕客戶和豪華酒店構成的**生活圈／社會環境**。」

****world = 具有某種特定生活方式、人物和規則的社會環境****

This is closely related to #4, but broader than a profession.

6. ****someone's world = person's life, experiences, and concerns (某人的生活世界) — 某人的生活／人生重心****

****Meaning:**** Everything that forms an important part of a particular person's life and experience.

Practice 12

> “Her children are the centre of her **world**.”

「她的孩子是她**生活的中心／人生最重要的部分**。」

Practice 13

> “His **world** changed completely after he moved abroad.”

「移居海外後，他的**整個生活和人生經驗**徹底改變了。」

****someone's world = 構成某人生活、經驗、關係和關注重心的整體****

7. ****someone/something means the world to someone — 對某人極其重要****

This develops from #6.

Practice 14

> “My family **means the world to me**.”

「我的家人對我來說**極其重要**，是我生命中最珍貴的一部分。」

Practice 15

> “Your support **means the world to her**.”

「你的支持對她說**非常重要、意義重大**。」

mean the world to someone = 對某人極其重要或珍貴

8. **someone's world falls apart / collapses** — 人生彷彿崩塌

Another common figurative extension of someone's personal world.

Practice 16

> “His **world fell apart** when he lost his job and home.”

「失去工作和住所後，他感覺自己的**人生彷彿整個崩塌了**。」

Practice 17

> “For a while, it felt as though her **world had collapsed**.”

「有一段時間，她覺得自己的**生活彷彿徹底崩潰了**。」

someone's world falls apart = 某人的生活、關係或安全感受到重大破壞

9. **world = imagined/fictional environment** (虛構／想像世界) — 世界；世界觀中的環境

Meaning: A complete imagined setting created in a book, game, film, story, etc.

Practice 18

> “The novel creates a detailed fantasy **world**.”

「這本小說創造了一個細緻完整的**奇幻世界**。」

Practice 19

> “Players can explore a huge open **world**.”

「玩家可以探索一個龐大的開放**遊戲世界**。」

world = 故事、遊戲或想像中具有自己環境、人物及規則的完整空間

10. **world** = planet / celestial body capable of being imagined as a separate place (星球／天體世界) — 星球; 世界

Especially in science fiction and astronomy-related language.

Practice 20

> “The story is set on a distant **world**.”

「故事設定在一個遙遠的**星球／世界**。」

Practice 21

> “Scientists continue to search for other habitable **worlds**.”

「科學家繼續尋找其他可能適合居住的**星球**。」

world = 被視為一個獨立環境或可能存在生命的星球／天體

11. **a world of** + difference/trouble/opportunity (巨大程度) — 極大的; 大量的

Here, **world** figuratively means a very large amount or degree.

Practice 22

> “A good pair of headphones can make a **world of difference**.”

「一副好的耳機可以帶來**極大的差別／明顯改善**。」

Practice 23

> “A little preparation can save you a **world of trouble**.”

「多做一點準備可以替你避免**很多麻煩**。」

a world of something = 非常大量／非常大的程度

Especially common:

> **a world of difference** = 天壤之別／極大的差異

12. **the best/biggest/etc. in the world — 世界上最.....的**

Meaning: Comparing something with everything or everyone globally.

Practice 24

> “It is one of the largest cities in the **world**.”

「它是**世界上**最大的城市之一。」

Practice 25

> “She wants to become the best player in the **world**.”

「她希望成為**世界上**最出色的選手。」

in the world = 在全球所有相關人物／事物之中

13. **real world (現實生活) — 現實世界; 真實生活環境**

This is a very useful family extension.

Meaning: Actual everyday life, as opposed to theory, imagination, simulations, school exercises, or idealized situations.

Practice 26

> “Students need experience solving **real-world** problems.”

「學生需要有解決**現實生活中真實問題**的經驗。」

Practice 27

> “The theory works differently in the ****real world****.”

「這個理論到了****現實環境中****，實際運作方式有所不同。」

****real world** = 理論、想像或模擬以外，實際日常生活中的真實環境

14. ****worldwide** = throughout the world (全球各地) — 全球的; 遍及世界的 / 在全球

****Worldwide**** can be an adjective or adverb.

Practice 28

> “The company sells its products ****worldwide****.”

「這家公司在****全球各地****銷售產品。」

Practice 29

> “The film became a ****worldwide**** success.”

「這部電影在****全球範圍內****取得成功。」

****worldwide** = 涉及、存在或發生於全球各地

15. ****world-famous** = known throughout the world — 世界知名的; 享譽全球的

Practice 30

> “The city is ****world-famous**** for its architecture.”

「這座城市以其建築而****享譽全球****。」

Practice 31

> “She became a ****world-famous**** musician.”

「她成為了一位****世界知名的音樂家****。」

****world-famous = 在許多國家和地區都廣為人知的****

16. ****world-class = among the best internationally — 世界級的; 達到國際頂尖水平的****

****Meaning:**** Of a quality comparable with the best available anywhere in the world.

Practice 32

> “The city has a ****world-class**** transport system.”

「這座城市擁有****達到國際頂尖水平的****交通系統。」

Practice 33

> “She is a ****world-class**** athlete.”

「她是一名****世界頂尖水平的****運動員。」

****world-class = 質素或能力達到全球頂尖標準的****

17. ****worldview = overall way of understanding life and society (世界觀) — 世界觀; 整體人生觀****

****Meaning:**** A person's broad set of beliefs about life, society, morality, reality, and how the world works.

Practice 34

> “Travel changed his ****worldview****.”

「旅行改變了他的****世界觀／理解人生和社會的整體方式****。」

Practice 35

> “Our experiences shape our ****worldview****.”

「我們的經歷會塑造我們的****世界觀****。」

****worldview = 一個人用來理解世界、社會和人生的一整套基本觀念****

18. **worldly = experienced in practical/social life (處世老練的) — 世故的; 熟悉人情世故的**

This is an important related form, but its meaning is **not simply “related to the world.”**

Meaning: Experienced in practical life and knowledgeable about how people and society behave.

Practice 36

> “Despite his young age, he seemed surprisingly **worldly**.”

「雖然年紀輕輕，他卻顯得非常**世故、熟悉人情世故**。」

Practice 37

> “She was more **worldly** than her sheltered classmates.”

「相比生活環境較受保護的同學，她更**懂得社會人情和現實處世方式**。」

worldly = 對社會、人情及現實生活有很多經驗、較世故老練的

19. **worldly = material/secular rather than spiritual (物質世俗的) — 世俗的; 物質層面的**

A second established sense of **worldly**.

Practice 38

> “He had little interest in **worldly** wealth.”

「他對**世俗的物質財富**沒有太大興趣。」

Practice 39

> “She gave up many **worldly** possessions.”

「她放棄了很多**世俗物質財產**。」

worldly = 與物質、金錢及世俗生活有關，而非精神或宗教層面的

20. **out of this world = extraordinarily good/impressive — 好得不得了; 非凡出眾的**

This is a very common idiom and useful family extension.

Practice 40

> “The food was **out of this world**.”

「那些食物**好吃得不得了／非常出色**。」

Practice 41

> “The view from the mountain was **out of this world**.”

「山上的景色**美得非比尋常**。」

out of this world = 好得遠超一般水平, 令人非常驚艷的

Usually positive and informal.

Important distinction: **world vs Earth**

Earth

specifically refers to the physical planet.

> “The Earth orbits the Sun.”

「地球繞太陽運行。」

world

can mean:

- * Earth,
- * all humanity,
- * society,
- * an area of activity,
- * someone's personal life,
- * an imagined reality.

So **world** is far broader.

Important distinction: **world vs society**

society

= people living together under shared institutions, customs, and structures

world

can refer much more broadly to all people, reality, a profession, an imagined realm, etc.

> “the business world”

is natural.

> “the business society”

does not normally mean the same thing.

Important distinction: **world vs environment**

environment

= the physical/social surroundings in which someone or something exists

world

can include not only surroundings but also:

- * people,
- * activities,
- * institutions,
- * relationships,
- * experiences.

In your sentence:

> **outside world**

is broader and more expressive than simply **outside environment**.

It makes the contrast feel like:

****the listener inside a quiet personal bubble vs everything else outside it.****

Important distinction: **worldly vs worldwide**

These are completely different.

**worldly**

= socially experienced / concerned with material life

> “a worldly person”

> = 世故老練的人

**worldwide**

= throughout the whole world

> “worldwide sales”

> = 全球銷售

Do not confuse them.

Family-extension note

Following our updated Golden Manual, these deserve explicit inclusion:

* ****outside world**** = 外界

* ****real world**** = 現實世界／真實生活

* ****business/art/fashion world**** = 商界／藝術界／時裝界

* ****someone's world**** = 某人的生活／人生重心

* ****mean the world to someone**** = 對某人極其重要

* ****a world of difference**** = 極大的差異

* ****worldwide**** = 全球的／遍及全球

* ****world-famous**** = 世界知名的

* ****world-class**** = 世界級的

* ****worldview**** = 世界觀

* ****worldly**** = 世故的；世俗物質的

* ****out of this world**** = 非凡出色的

These are not all separate meanings of bare ****world****, but they are highly useful members of the practical word family.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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the world — Earth	地球以及存在於地球上的人類、國家和自然環境整體
the world — humanity	全體人類或整個人類社會
world — external reality	某人自身或私人空間以外, 由其他人、活動和環境構成的外部現實
business/art/etc. world	由某個共同職業、興趣或活動形成的領域／圈子
social world	具有某種特定生活方式、人物和規則的社會環境
someone's world	構成某人生活、關係、經驗和人生重心的整體
mean the world to someone	對某人極其重要、珍貴或具有重大情感價值
world falls apart	某人的生活、安全感或重要關係受到重大破壞
fictional world	故事、遊戲或想像中具有自己環境和規則的完整世界
world — planet	被視為獨立環境、尤其可能存在生命的星球
a world of something	非常大量或非常大的程度
in the world	在全球所有相關人物或事物之中
real world	理論、想像或模擬以外的真實日常生活環境
worldwide	涉及、存在或發生於全球各地的／在全球各地
world-famous	在許多國家和地區都廣為人知的
world-class	質素或能力達到全球頂尖水平的
worldview	用來理解世界、社會和人生的一整套基本觀念
worldly — experienced	對社會和人情世故有豐富經驗、較老練的
worldly — secular/material	與物質和世俗生活有關, 而非精神層面的
out of this world	遠超一般水平、令人非常驚艷的

For your original sentence

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside ****world****.”

The exact meaning is:

****world = 自己當下的私人空間和內在體驗以外, 由其他人、活動、聲音和環境構成的整個現實****

So:

****the outside world = 周圍整個外界現實****

And the metaphor means:

****戴上降噪耳機後, 使用者彷彿進入了一個安靜的私人空間, 而外界的人聲、交通聲和各種活動都像被整體按下了靜音鍵。****

